

Learning without Learning in the New Normal: College Education Students Lived Experiences in Blended Learning Modality

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Abstract

Blended learning has been the modality used by higher education to continue quality education amidst the pandemic. Thus, this study investigated and explored the lived experiences of students at Cebu Technological University-Moalboal Campus. The theory of distance education or distance learning is reflected in the three historical approaches namely: the theories of autonomy and independence, theory of industrialization and the theories of interaction and communication. The data were analysed with 11 participants using the Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA); based on Moustakas' Modified Van Kaam Approach. Four emerging core themes were generated such as the (Theme 1) challenges and struggles in blended learning, (Theme 2) student's preference in learning, (Theme 3) motivation is the key, and (Theme 4) internet websites are at ease. With these four core themes, it can be gleaned that those students are struggling in a blended learning modality. These lived experiences of the college students may propose an action plan for the university to take explore pedagogical remedies to address the student's difficulties in learning.

Keywords: Blended Learning, Challenges, Struggles, Internet Websites, COVID-19 Pandemic

Introduction

Pandemics have been the greatest challenge in recent days. Everything, especially the educational system darkened as a result of those occurrences. Blended learning is a new educational trend as well as a new way of teaching among professors and students in the new normal. Blended learning (BL) has a significant impact on all aspects of life. According to Stubbs et al. (2006), this modality addresses the needs of learners in terms of their learning goals and learning environment. In addition, learners nowadays face significant barriers to blended learning for a variety of reasons, including restricted or non-existent internet connectivity, budgetary constraints, insufficient access to technological devices, and moral and emotional support. As a result, typical modules are transformed into the BL approach using the social constructivist technique, which improves educational differentiation, reduces lecture time, and stimulates repetition (Dalsgaard & Godsk, 2007). BL offers students an effective learning experience with active learning (Bonk et al., 2002). With flexible active learning and more feedback, BL provides students with an authentic learning experience (Bonk et al., 2002). Furthermore, research have found that this modality is beneficial among students. However, few research have focused on the real-life experiences of college education students at Cebu Technological University-Moalboal

Campus in this mode of learning. Online Distance Learning (ODL) was the only mode used to shed and continue learning in the said university. And now, blended learning is another new mode use in learning. The question then became how this blended learning modality affects the students' life experiences, particularly the challenges they faced.

E-learning poses a significant threat to students' lifestyles. According to Sharma 2020, a pandemic provides effectiveness, flexibility, cost-efficiency, and time savings, though physical learning cannot be replaced by a virtual classroom. Teachers' presentation skills, technical competencies, virtual management tactics, and capacity to engage students through virtual communication, course material organization, quick response, content clarity, and feedback are all examples of communication practices (Moore et al., 2005; Partlow et al., 2003). With the use of technology, teachers can utilize technology to improve the quality of education. While e-learning has some drawbacks, it also has some benefits, and "blended learning" refers to mixing these benefits with traditional classroom learning (Kharb & Samantha, 2016). It brings a lot of tribulations, but it gives motivation to all to continue in education. Failure is reserved for those who are easily discouraged and lack the ability to persevere. Global competitiveness is pressuring universities to excel at relevant and innovative knowledge generation. Innovations help to

solve societal issues. Perhaps a new way of thinking will help to improve the relevance and sustainability of every students (Alexander Kyei Edwards et al., 2018). There are many reasons that are unknown that cannot be explained smoothly. Academic stress, coping, and social-cultural adaption are all issues that university students face, necessitating a deeper understanding of the aspects that affect their psychological well-being (Sri Nurhayati Selian et al., 2020). Perhaps it would cause doubt about someone's strength. It is difficult to learn in this new normal, but it is not impossible because anything is possible. There is no doubting that the introduction of ICT into the classroom has provided a significant challenge to instructors in terms of developing an effective teaching and learning process. On the other hand, school administrators advise instructors to develop their ability and self-confidence in using ICT to improve teaching quality. To make learning possible despite the difficulties pupils face. They can use ICT to make the seemingly impossible possible (Mohd et al., 2021).

To face this change, students must be flexible in a way they feel comfortable. Having insufficient gadgets to employ in this new normal could be embarrassing. E-module based worksheets supplied to students, according to Vina Serevina et al., 2022, boost students' critical thinking skills and education quality. It's one of the challenges learners endure, but Filipinos are resilient. Learning with learning is the ultimate goal, but do all learners learn effectively considering the geographical factors of some students. This dynamic learning environment allows students to develop intellectually, with thought-provoking ideas and perspectives from which they can grow as individuals. It goes into how stress, brain functioning, learning styles, and social and emotional concerns affect student behavior (Bluestein, 2008).

Change is the only constant in this world. Students must be adaptable in order to learn in a way that they enjoy. Social networking for self-directed learning has partial mediation effects on lifelong learning and full mediation effects on lifelong learning. It suggest that lectures should assist students in honing their self-directed learning skills, good attitudes toward ICT, and social networking skills in lifelong learning by providing appropriate learning techniques and a proper teaching and learning environment (Umi Kalsum Mohd Sellah et al., 2020). Having insufficient gadgets to use in this new normal particularly in this new mode of learning can cause degradation. Despite all the adversities that blended learning has offered, students can still be able to achieve their dreams since learning is our ultimate goal. However, there is one major point

that must be addressed: do all learners learn effectively when some of their classmates are physically separated? This study, will discuss further blended learning as it provides many benefits to students, instructors, and parents, especially in these difficult times. Students are complying with the requirements given by their respective professor in a particular subject. Thus, students' learning and capability is impacted to the performance and pedagogical approach given by their professors (Rommel Lizandro Crispin et al., 2022).

Numerous works of literature show that blended learning is widely used even before the pandemic and is now the new normal. It is used in the educational sector to address a contextual event. A literature review strategy with qualitative data analysis methodologies was applied. Blended learning classes can give students some flexibility that allows them to learn at their own convenience (Singh, 2003). Blended learning offers numerous experiences in learning that match the individual preferences of students in learning. With this, it can positively impact the academic achievements of the students. However, it's crucial to remember that students must be actively engaged in the success of blended learning (Gradel & Edson, 2011). In fact, students said they preferred a blended learning modality since it is a combination of virtual and physical instructions (Atallah & Moussa-Inaty, 2013).

There are several challenges in blended learning. However, few scholars have tried to extend distance education theories in order to address these challenges. Bunderson (2003), suggested the use of the notion to engage in collaborative discourse (Xin, 2002). Garrison and Vaughan (2008), used the framework of a community of inquiry (COI) in conjunction with conceptions of social, instructional, and cognitive presence in order to contextualize and examine the design of blended learning in the university level (Akyol et al., 2009). Several theories have been utilized in the creation of blended learning settings (1993) such as motivation theory (Keller's, 1983), and the theory of structuration which examines the connection between social structure and individual action. While some study of blended learning is theoretically sound, the majority of previous research has focused on describing or solving specific problems rather than developing a cohesive theory. Many studies considered theory as merely background information that describes findings or outcomes; thus, distance learning requires researchers to focus on psychological rather than physical distance.

This study is intended to determine the lived experiences of students in the new normal. Most students are exhausted because of the adjustment that they used to do. Generally, the students experience this because they can work at their own pace while still having teachers available to support them in areas where they need it. Like everyone else, they want to experience and be back to normal again, and most importantly they want to improve their level of understanding through their exploration in searching information available online. It is impossible to predict how long it will take to overcome the students in this kind of situation. If given the chance, blended learning can replace lecture-based, one-size-fits-all instruction with student-centered, technology-enhanced instruction that allows students to learn at their own pace while learning information and techniques. This study looked at the lived experiences of students in dealing with the challenges in this online learning modality.

Research Questions

This study explicated the lived experiences of college students at Cebu Technological University- Moalboal Campus in a blended learning modality. Specifically, the study delves into the following specific questions:

1. What are the challenges and struggles of the students at Cebu Technological University- Moalboal University?
2. What are the most common problems encountered in blended learning?
3. What are the negative effects of their experiences in blended learning?
4. What is your preferred mode of instruction between the two types of means in a blended learning modality?
5. How do these challenges motivate you to study?
6. Do you still learn despite the access ready to made answers on the internet?
7. How does it affect to you the sites on the internet?
8. What is the meaning of their experience?

Literature Review

The different surveyed materials regarding the college education students lived experiences in blended learning modalities are discussed in this section to provide the concept of the research. These articles were scrutinized with attention in order to extract relevant and trustworthy data to support the current investigation. This section explains and elaborates on the college of education students lived experienced in

blended learning modality. The qualitative and mixed-method research designs are used by the researchers in this study. The works of literature in both local and international studies assert one thing; the necessity to know the blended learning modality lived experiences of the college of education students.

Due to an unanticipated epidemic, the educational system has shifted putting all students as well as instructors in a difficult situation. As a result, blended learning has been demonstrated in order to continue quality education and lifetime learning. Blended learning is a product of the digital revolution, according to Selwyn and Jandric (2020), and it is increasingly being adopted as a new delivery method by institutions of higher education around the world. Blended learning environments provide students with significant support and opportunities to actively participate in defining their own learning while also allowing for a more in-depth review of course content (Montgomery et al. 2019).

Higher education could benefit from a blended learning experience, especially in the aftermath of a pandemic (Jones & Sharma, 2020). It can be observed that a blended learning method provides students with a high-impact learning outcome. Though it may appear difficult, it is a simple technique to the interest of students in learning. Otherwise, other materials discussed the various issues that this modality has faced, such as enabling students' learning, flexibility, interaction, and learning atmosphere and styles. Higher education also provides learners with a greater level of flexibility. This reaches a substantial level of affix in the connection between the students and their teacher. Little by little, this lets students who may be under suspicion in certain environments reach out. Through blended learning, learners take part in online courses to complete their tasks.

The blended learning experience in online resources and information to meet the needs of students' level of interest they use the online platform to gather information. Providing chances for professional engagement enhances educators to manage their time. It utilized interactive knowledge check as a crucial feature of active learning in blended learning modality, as a flipped classroom has been found to boost student engagement. (Guillén-Gámez et al., 2020; Owston et al., 2019). It utilized interactive knowledge checks as a crucial feature of active learning in both our online and face-to-face components, as flipped classrooms have been found to boost student engagement. When quizzes are integrated into the design, learning aims are achieved (Van Alten et al., 2019).

Furthermore, many scholars have researched the effects of online learning on education (Akinbadewa & Sofowora, 2020). Online learning has its disadvantages, but researchers identified that online learning has several advantages, such as the continuity of education, continuous lifelong learning, and the ability to diminish the expenditure related to traditional education. Yet, without doubt, the most desired responses were the lack of poor internet connection and, above all, the lack of outdated equipment. Hence, there are obstacles to doing learning activities at home. Poor motivation and time management are unique to poor motivation. A blended learning model often requires students to utilize technology outside of the classroom.

According to Castro (2019), blended learning has five factors that affect students. With these factors, students are able to expand their individual learning styles. Teacher-student builds a strong relationship and uses real time in discussing lessons with the use of technology, and it strengthens the performance in the classroom and the effectiveness of teaching and is perceived as a helpful contribution to the blended learning approach. Technology plays a vital role in blended learning as it serves as the means of communication. Because of technology, students are able to engage, explore, and discover new things. They are also able to get feedback from their teacher about their performances on where they are good and where they need to improve. In blended learning, students are taught how to be more self-reliant as they are able to understand lessons on their own. Though blended learning is not suitable for everyone, especially those students in mountainous areas, it is still implemented to continue the quality of education despite the pandemic.

Learners and teachers are in different situations and limitations which include methods of teaching, and many more (Weinhandl et al., 2020). In addition, children whose parents that have lack the educational background and those who do not live with their parents are lack of guidance; (Hebebe et al., 2020). Remote education is also difficult to navigate. To address this issue, some institutions may need to use a hybrid method of onsite and remote learning to ensure that the appropriate measurements of social distancing were implemented. Online learning extended beyond the educational system to the learning experiences of students when it came to examining research and instructional materials.

Moreover, to improve the knowledge and understanding of the students being taught, they will

need to possess different approaches like reflection, teamwork, cooperation, multiculturalism, critical thinking, and problem-solving in order to have a positive outcome in the different activities they acquire (Milad, 2019). Students must practice and refine these approaches incrementally when learning them. Learners are given a strong foundation in learning to learn independently. It will increase students' readiness for learning and corroborate learning through evocative assessment to keep diverse approaches distinct.

The various articles mentioned in this section provided a diverse range of perspectives on blended learning. Considering the several perspectives when attempting to comprehend students' blended learning live experiences are crucial. In blended learning, students have the opportunity to study and learn on their own. Blended learning allows students to learn at their own pace by providing flexible time periods that may be tailored to their needs. However, due to different problems in blended learning, not all students do so fully. The live experience of blended learning should be evaluated in order to understand the underlying obstacles and oppositions of students both online and in person. These articles provide a solid foundation for understanding what to expect from the results of this investigation. These surveyed resources can undoubtedly support the research's conclusion.

Methodology

The Heideggerian Phenomenology design was used in this qualitative investigation. The primary purpose of this study is to explain and investigate student's lived experiences in a blended learning modality. The researchers performed in-depth interviews and came up with relevant open-ended questions for the study. These questions gave the researchers the direction they needed to get a better grasp and validate the results.

Participants

The participants in this study are students in Cebu Technological University- Moalboal Campus (2nd Semester of SY 2021-2022). To gather relevant information, it will cater to those students who experience the blended learning modality. The reason for selecting this study was to understand the blended learning experiences of the students. All the students were from Year 2 and had prior experience of having blended learning in the same program. Among the four classes of many students, 11 students were part of the study. The primary source of data came from the

individual interviews of eleven students. Different methods were used to collect data for triangulation. Each individual chose whether to participate or not. Since the instrument is confidential, there was a determination of the students who participated. All of their answer in the interview that we conducted were recorded.

Instruments

The research instrument used by the researchers in collecting or gathering data is through virtual interview. The virtual interview is consist of seven questions per respondents to some education students as target participants of the study. The researchers choose interview because it is not hustle and it takes lesser time in gathering some important data. Participants are given ample of time to answer the question comprehensively. The answers of the participants has been collected to ensure unbiased. Then the type of sampling used in the research study is non-probability sampling. The researchers will use any kind of treatment to explain the data gathered from the different perceptions of the respondents. After collecting the answers, researchers analyzed the different perceptions answered by the respondents and make a generalization afterward.

Procedure

In this qualitative study, the Heideggerian Phenomenology design was applied. This study's main goal is to explain and explore students' lived experiences in a mixed learning environment. The researchers conducted in-depth interviews and devised pertinent open-ended study questions. These questions provided the researchers with the guidance they needed to better understand and validate the findings. The study's participants were chosen using a purposive sample technique to expound on their lived experiences in a blended learning modality. Purposive sampling is a nonprobability technique in which the researcher selects study participants based on inclusion criteria using his or her own judgment. Furthermore, an inclusion criterion was devised in order to select relevant participants for this study. The research involved a total of 11 people.

Ethical Considerations

Integrity and transparency are crucial in doing research. Ethical considerations applied in this study include voluntary participation, informed consent, anonymity, confidentiality, do no harm, respect oneself, and results from communication. Participants

in this study are fully aware of these and feel comfortable while answering the survey questionnaire.

Result

After analyzing data, the researchers came up with four major themes, namely: Theme 1: Challenges and struggles in blended learning, Theme 2: Student's preferences in learning, Theme 3: Motivation is the key, and Theme 4: Internet websites are at ease. These four themes highlighted the students lived experience in a blended learning modality. (Please see Table 1. *Data Analysis* [Appendix 1])

Discussion

Theme 1: Challenges and struggles in blended learning

The majority of the participants would agree. Students are not being taught adequately during this pandemic, and they are not learning (Alvarez, 2020). Educational institutions have numerous issues, including the supply of appropriate instructional technology and adequate teacher training assistance. Abdublah et al. (2020) It also notes that students experienced challenges such as technological issues, instructor defects, difficulties with online assessments, attitudes toward online learning, limited resources, and university council choices (Dahmash, 2020).

Student 4 mentioned that,

"The most common problems I encountered in blended learning are, of course, we have an online platform, but it's very different from face-to-face classes as before, because of the barriers. And as an online learning modality, it uses a strong data or wifi connection in order for us to have a virtual class, and its barrier is when encountering an unstable connection while we're staying at home and the people around us or the surroundings may interrupt the learning progress. For example, family problems, noisy neighbors (videoke), and so on."

Students are required to complete work that is similar to what they do in the classroom at school, at home, or at home learning. But in some instances, there are unexpected occasions that internet connection is hinder through various aspects such as weather, location, unwarmed interruption for a telecommunication

connection and brownout. Much more, the applications and websites that students will be need to use in their classes demand strong data stability and low connection might concern to unattended the meet up. Students have also reported affective issues and distractions through neighboring noises. Some students are living near places that have much houses where living family are having celebration, feast, or occasions that they tend to be loud. Learning in online class is still in going despite any occasions and students are challenge to such noise distractions while listening during the meet ups.

Student 6 stated that,

“The negative consequences of our blended learning experiences are, as previously stated, when encountering unstable connections, also having no money to buy a load, noisy surroundings, lack of equipment or materials at home, like an electrical, nursing, or doctorate course, always facing or using a laptop or cellular phone that can penetrate learning progress.”

Slow or inconsistent internet connections, as well as limited access from rural houses, might cause pupils to fall behind academically. Students who do not have access to the internet or who rely solely on their cell phone for access are half a grade point behind those who do. This chasm has far-reaching ramifications that may last a lifetime. Furthermore, students who could only access the internet via their cell phone at home struggled to access the resources available on the internet, whether owing to sluggish connectivity or data usage limits imposed by local service providers. It is a mistake to assume that because most students have a smartphone, they have sufficient access. Online learning is happening at house where there could be limited access to resources to be use in class. Those who only have a cell phone access do no better than those with no internet access at all. The availability of resources give more advantages to students who has competed to don't have.

Student 2 stated that,

“When the distance learning was observed, I wasn't able to adapt quickly. Thus, the pressure was intense, and my mental health was shaken.”

Everyone's health and safety are of the biggest importance at this time, and distance learning is the only viable choice. However, in the long term, students have discovered the difficulties of online education, particularly on one's mental health, which

may exacerbate for those who already have mental health issues. Students find it more difficult to learn new knowledge, and while sitting in front of the computer, they feel physically exhausted. Virtual learning weariness is real, and it can cause students anxiety and stress. In online learning, the lack of social interaction leads to feelings of loneliness, motivation, and isolation. Students in a typical classroom have a predetermined schedule during the school day. When it's time to get ready for school, go to class, finish homework, have lunch with friends, and participate in extracurricular activities. Things are never the same when it comes to online learning. As a result, students procrastinate and postpone tasks, causing deadlines to be missed. As a result, students feel pressured, stressed, and anxious.

The Challenges and struggles in blended learning theme is one of the most serious topics among the college of students in blended learning modality. The many textural languages formed by the horizons led to the conclusion that students are indeed challenge in financial, health, poor internet connection and geographical factors. This image symbolizes an appeal to all administrators and institution to revisit the situations and challenges of students in blended learning.

Theme 2: Student's preferable between Modular Distance Learning (MDL) or Online Distance Learning (ODL)

In this time of pandemic, all of the students are preferred in online distance learning (ODL). US Department of Education (2020) mentioned that online learning options, as well as the utilization of open educational resources and other technology, are thought to improve educational productivity by speeding up learning, lowering expenses connected with instructional materials or program delivery, and better utilizing teacher time. This type of learning is suitable in this time of pandemic but the online problem is the internet connection.

Student 2 said that,

“I preferred Online Distance Learning, why? Since this mode of learning encompasses sufficient guidance, live discussions, and strategic assessments to students. Not just that, it also provides/allows the learners to interact and participate somehow by giving assigned activities and class demonstrations.”

One of the students deliberately explained that online distance learning provides interaction and

communication between students and their teachers. By providing guidance, live discussion, and strategies that assess the student's needs in learning.

Student 10 stated that,

“Both modes of learning are helpful for us to gain new knowledge and information even if you are not in school but for me I think I would prefer for having the online classes. With the online classes, even though it gives many negative impacts to the student's still I believe it is a way more helpful compared to the MDL. It's a way more challenging and would help us students to have an active collaborative learning wherein we can easily access with our teachers. In which we can ask them through in a synchronous classes for the difficulties of our confusions that we may encounter during the given tasks or performances that they give to us. In that way, the problems you may have in mind would be address ahead of time.”

Clearly, the statement of student 10 explained and compared the difference between online distance learning and modular distance learning. Both modes of learning are beneficial and can help you learn new things even if you are not in school and usually stay at home. There are many hindrances to online distance learning, but the student believed that this is more beneficial in modular distance learning. Students can be assessed for active, collaborative learning through online distance learning, and teachers can readily assess the students. In online distance learning, students can simply ask questions when they have difficulty in the classes or with the assignments or performances they are provided. The teachers can simply answer the students' inquiries ahead of time.

Student 9 said that,

“Despite having troubles in the blended learning, I think it is still better the online distance learning because I get hear teachers discussion, ask questions if haven't understood a certain topic and there is at least a good amount of teacher student interaction and for me it feels more of like classroom than modular. Maybe in the mode of instruction, blended learning wins.”

Student 9 mentioned that blended learning has many difficulties, but she still chooses online blended learning. In online distance learning, I have an opportunity to hear the teachers' discussion, and the students can easily ask questions if they don't

understand the topic. Also, there is still interaction between the students and the teachers.

Even in the time of a pandemic, education still continues and is pursued. However, they are having difficulty adapting to online distance learning and manipulating technological tools. One of these is internet connection. Another is lack of resources such as gadgets, computers, laptops, etc. However, students discover ways to adapt to the new mode of learning and have high levels of contact with teachers.

Theme 3: Motivation is the key

Students in this time of pandemic is more motivated on having online distance learning compared to other modalities. This mode of learning is found to be more convenient and effective as it doesn't require more efforts like going to school every day attending classes physically. Instead, this kind of learning modality can be done anywhere that is convenient for the students as long as there's a stable internet connection. The only barrier of having this kind of learning modality is the internet connection.

Student 7 stated that,

“Even though there are a lot of barriers and disappointments to studying, I have to be strong in order to surpass this situation and to be positive no matter what the ups and downs are because I have the goals to aim for.”

The participant wants to imply that regardless of all the hindrances that she had encounter in this learning modality, she remained positive and extended her patience to overcome all of those adversity because she has goals that meant to be achieved.

Student 10 mentioned that,

“It motivates me to move forward and gives me a step to reach my goals in life. I didn't make that one as a negative impact instead I make it as a new door of opportunities for me to improve myself and become a better person.”

Challenges are taken as a motivation in reaching ones goals. It serves as stepping stone to fulfill a certain aspirations. Challenges are taken positively by the participants as it offers new doors of opportunities to enhance their capabilities as students to become a competent individuals.

Motivation theme emphasis that students becomes

more positive in dealing with all the challenges in this online learning modality. Even if it has several challenges but they take it positively so that they can move forward and reach their dreams.

Theme 4: Internet websites are at ease

Less educated people are going to find Internet resources more useful in less educated users. Many respondents agree that the Internet is helpful for narrowing the knowledge of students in the blended learning modality. The internet is the easiest and most convenient means to find the information we need, including news and a range of other useful information. Simply type the name of a website address or use a search engine to find it, in seconds the information that we find we get (R H Puspita and D Rohedi 2018)

Student 4 stated that it's more important to evaluate the credibility of the information's in the internet before copying it. Because not all answers in the internet are reliable. She said that,

"Yes, I still learn despite the access to ready-made answers on the internet. Why? Because if a student has the spirit of curiosity, he or she must find a way to determine whether or not the ready-made answers are reliable. If it's not, I will study its beyond. If the ready-made answers are correct, I will study how that came up."

Student 7 said that,

"The sites on the internet websites from various sources are not reliable most of the time. You have to dig deeper so that you won't get scammed or have false information. I experienced this last semester. We had our midterm examination. I got nervous and panicked that I couldn't remember what the answer was to that question, so I searched for it on Google. My teacher got angry with me and my classmates because we had both answers but she was unfamiliar with the answer. So, lesson learned: study the materials given to your teacher and don't be dependent on Google."

Some students experienced a false information that they have same experienced with their classmates. In which the answers they got in the internet are almost familiar. But, we can't controlled it, instead we need to be vigilant in answering. Always remember to be not dependent on the internet and be a good researcher.

Student 2 implied that,

"The internet sites are the bridge of understanding, and a tool to access when I'm confused with my web search. However, as a social media user, I have to be information literate, and possess the potential as an ideal entity, to really emphasize the significance of proper usage."

At some point, to be information literate is very crucial in the lives of the students because it helps them to analyze and be responsible in gathering information's.

Most of the lived experiences of the students encountered, indicates that being literate is one of the ability to be able to recognize information needed. Having the ability to know, locate, evaluate, and effectively the use information is very important. Even though we have different ways to evaluate information. But, as individual living in the digital age, we should know how to navigate the Web successfully, find the best materials, and evaluate and use them with confidence.

Conclusion

The passion and dedication of students lived experiences on blended learning modality is indispensable. They are still MOTIVATED to study despite many barriers, CHALLENGES, AND STRUGGLES in blended learning. Students need to engage in both MODULAR DISTANCE LEARNING (MDL) AND ONLINE DISTANCE LEARNING (ODL). Questions during examinations should not be copied from the INTERNET WEBSITES. These lived experiences may shed light that in this new learning modality, everyone has an important role to play. It is recommended that professors and instructors in the Higher Education Institution (HEI) should be keen on monitoring and tracking various websites online to avoid students from copying answers available online. The instructors should make questions that are not found and cannot be traced online where students can do copy-paste. And, also it is recommended that the professors/instructors should be more hands-on in teaching to ensure that students can maximize their learning experience.

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Table 1. *Data Analysis*

Horizons	Textural Language	Themes
“As the pandemic alarmed every individual, many changes happened, especially to cope with financial drought, limited access in transportation, the implementation of distance learning, and many more. Furthermore, my experiences were traumatizing but challenging at the same time. As a student, I used to learn from the traditional set up. When the distance learning was observed, I wasn't able to adapt quickly. Thus, the pressure was intense, and my mental health was shaken.” (S2) “The COVID-19 pandemic and resulting economic crisis has brought unprecedented challenges to the students. It left us students struggling. We/I faced financial challenges that put our education in jeopardy, had new living arrangements that made learning difficult, and often lacked the resources necessary to even log onto class online. The most struggling part is The poor connection, In a way that, I wanted to give up Already” (S11) “The most common problems I encountered in blended learning are, of course, we have an online platform, but it's very different from face-to-face classes as before, because of the barriers. And as an online learning modality, it uses a strong data or wifi connection in order for us to have a virtual class, and its barrier is when encountering an unstable connection while we're staying at home and the people around us or the surroundings may interrupt the learning progress. For example, family problems, noisy neighbors (videoke), and so on.” (S4) “The negative consequences of our blended learning experiences are, as previously stated, when encountering unstable connections, also having no money to buy a load, noisy surroundings, lack of equipment or materials at home, like an electrical, nursing, or doctorate course, always facing or using a laptop or cellular phone that can penetrate learning progress.” (S6) “I preferred Online Distance Learning, why? Since this mode of learning	<i>Several Challenges (financial, health, educational)</i> <i>Online Learning Barriers (Poor internet connection, geographical factors)</i>	<i>Challenges and Struggles in blended learning.</i>

encompasses sufficient guidance, live discussions, and strategic assessments to students. Not just that, it also provides/allows the learners to interact and participate somehow by giving assigned activities and class demonstrations.” (S2)

“Both modes of learning are helpful for us to gain new knowledge and information even if you are not in school but for me I think I would prefer for having the online classes. With the online classes, even though it gives many negative impacts to the students still I believe it is a way more helpful compared to the MDL. It’s a way more challenging and would help us students to have an active collaborative learning wherein we can easily access with our teachers. In which we can ask them through in a synchronous classes for the difficulties of our confusions that we may encounter during the given tasks or performances that they give to us. In that way, the problems you may have in mind would be address ahead of time.” (S10)

“Despite having troubles in the blended learning, I think it is still better the online distance learning because I get hear teachers discussion, ask questions if haven't understood a certain topic and there is at least a good amount of teacher student interaction and for me it feels more of like classroom than modular. Maybe in the mode of instruction, blended learning wins.” (S9)

“Even though there are a lot of barriers and disappointments to studying, I have to be strong in order to surpass this situation and to be positive no matter what the ups and downs are because I have the goals to aim for.” (S7)

“It motivates me to move forward and gives me a step to reach my goals in life. I didn’t make that one as a negative impact instead I make it as a new door of opportunities for me to improve myself and become a better person.” (S10)

“Yes, I still learn despite the access to ready-made answers on the internet. Why? Because if a student has the spirit of curiosity, he or she must find a way to determine whether or not the ready-made answers are reliable. If it's not, I will study it's beyond. If the ready-made answers are correct, I will study how that came up.” (S4)

“The sites on the internet websites from

Positive Effects of Choosing Online Learning Modality

Student’s preference in learning

Positive Effects of Having Modular Distance Learning

Online Learning Motivation to Students

Motivation is the key

Scrutinizing Reliable Information

Internet websites are at ease

various sources are not reliable most of the time. You have to dig deeper so that you won't get scammed or have false information. I experienced this last semester. We had our midterm examination. I got nervous and panicked that I couldn't remember what the answer was to that question, so I searched for it on Google. My teacher got angry with me and my classmates because we had both answers but she was unfamiliar with the answer. So, lesson learned: study the materials given to your teacher and don't be dependent on Google.” (S7)

“The internet sites are the bridge of understanding, and a tool to access when I'm confused with my web search. However, as a social media user, I have to be information literate, and possess the potential as an ideal entity, to really emphasize the significance of proper usage.” (S2)

Utilization of Internet websites